

COMMON GROUND

Stories. Spaces. Communities.

A report about access, designed as an access point.

Common Ground is a self-directed editorial design project. All survey findings, participant quotations, organizations, and financial values are modeled scenario content created to demonstrate publication design and information hierarchy. They should not be interpreted as real research.

Common Ground

Annual Cultural Report

*How people notice, understand, reach, and return to
cultural experiences across a city.*

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EDITOR'S NOTE

Culture begins before the program.

Culture is often described through institutions: museums, theaters, libraries, galleries, and festivals. But access is experienced at a much smaller scale. It begins with the price printed on a ticket, the confidence to enter a room, the bus that arrives after an evening program, and the feeling that the story being told includes you.

This report follows that sequence—from first notice to return visit—and asks how design can make each step easier to understand.



A public corridor becomes a cultural threshold through scale, visibility, and repeated visual cues.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Four findings shape the report.

68%

participated at least quarterly

41%

named cost as a barrier

34%

said time limited participation

26%

cited transportation friction

The numbers are illustrative. The editorial challenge is real: complex findings need order, hierarchy, and enough white space for interpretation.

OI

A city made of invitations.

*Participation begins long before
attendance. It begins when information
reaches someone in a form they can
understand and trust.*



ESSAY

Access is not a single doorway.

A sequence of recognition, understanding, effort, and return

A city can publish thousands of events and still leave residents uncertain about where they belong. The distance between awareness and participation is rarely explained by interest alone. People make decisions through a web of practical signals: cost, time, transportation, language, familiarity, and whether the environment feels designed for them.

For this illustrative report, participation is treated as a sequence rather than a single outcome. A resident must first encounter an invitation, understand what is being offered, decide that the experience is worth the effort, and feel comfortable enough to return. Each threshold can either widen access or quietly narrow it.

“The invitation is part of the experience. If the information feels difficult, the event already feels distant.”

FROM NOTICE TO RETURN

The geography of attention

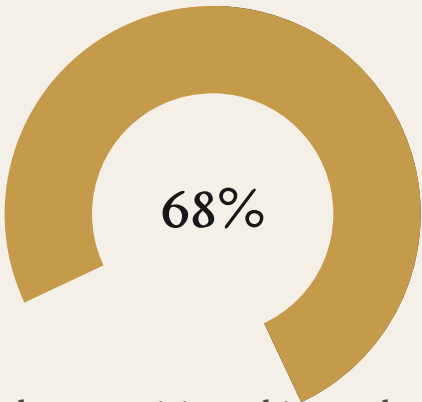
People do not discover culture through one channel. Some notice a poster while commuting; others follow a neighborhood organization, receive a school email, or hear about a program from a friend. These routes matter because each carries a different level of trust. A recommendation from a familiar person can make an unfamiliar institution feel possible.

Editorial hierarchy works in a similar way. It tells readers what deserves immediate attention, what can wait, and where evidence supports interpretation. A strong page does not demand that every element compete. It creates a sequence: headline, premise, body, evidence, caption, and source.

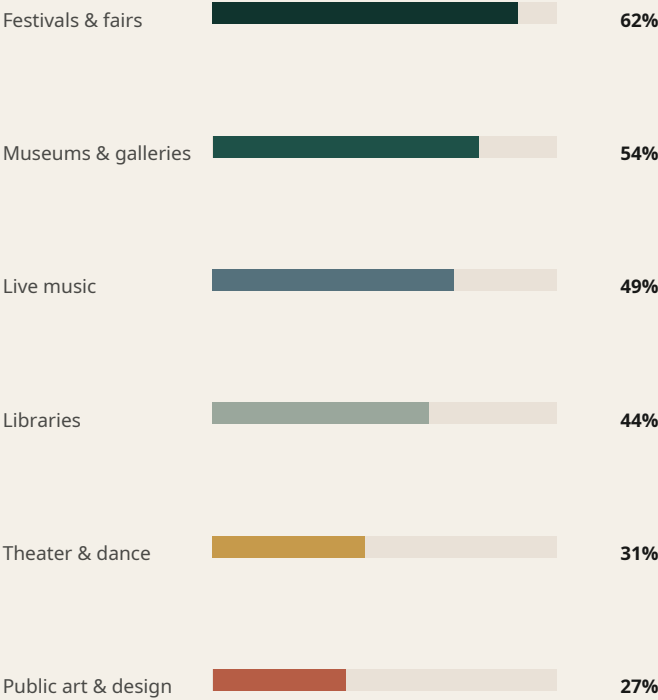
The publication therefore uses repeated page furniture and a limited set of styles, while allowing composition to change with the content. Dense reading pages sit beside image-led pauses. Data pages use the same baseline and margins as essays, so the report feels coherent even when the visual language shifts.

DATA OVERVIEW

Participation at a glance



of respondents participated in a cultural activity at least once per quarter.

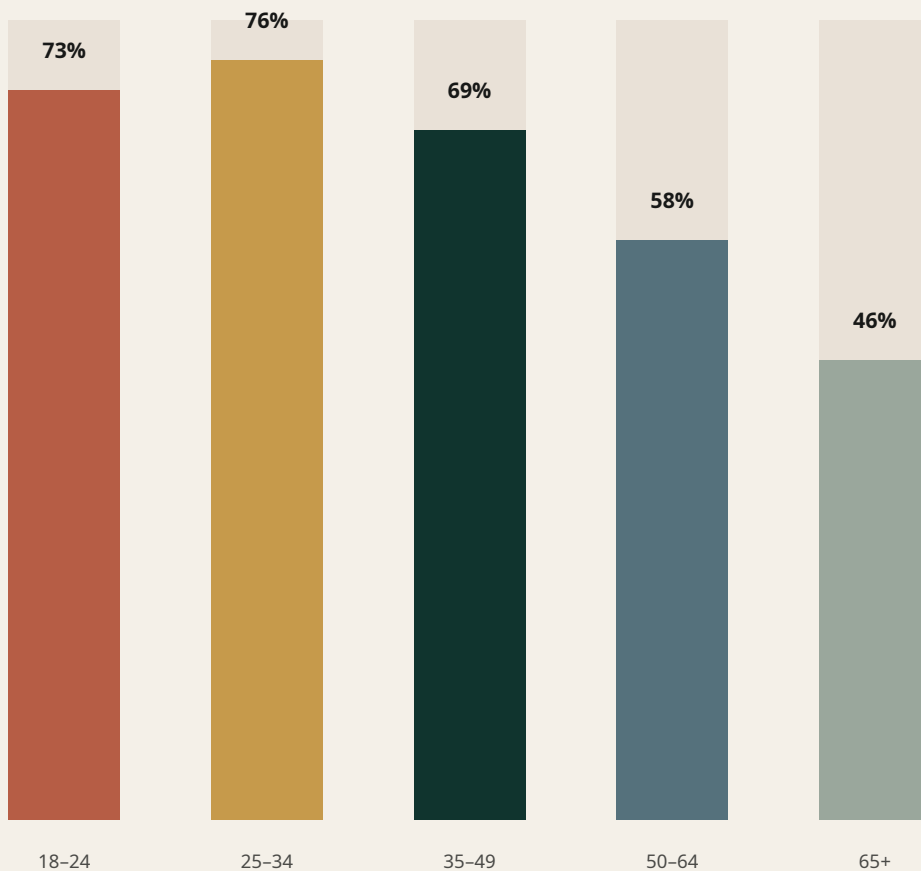


Base: 1,204 modeled respondents. Multiple activities could be selected.

WHO PARTICIPATES

Age changes the pattern, not the value of participation.

Younger respondents reported a broader mix of informal and event-based participation. Older respondents placed greater value on libraries, local history, and programs with predictable schedules.

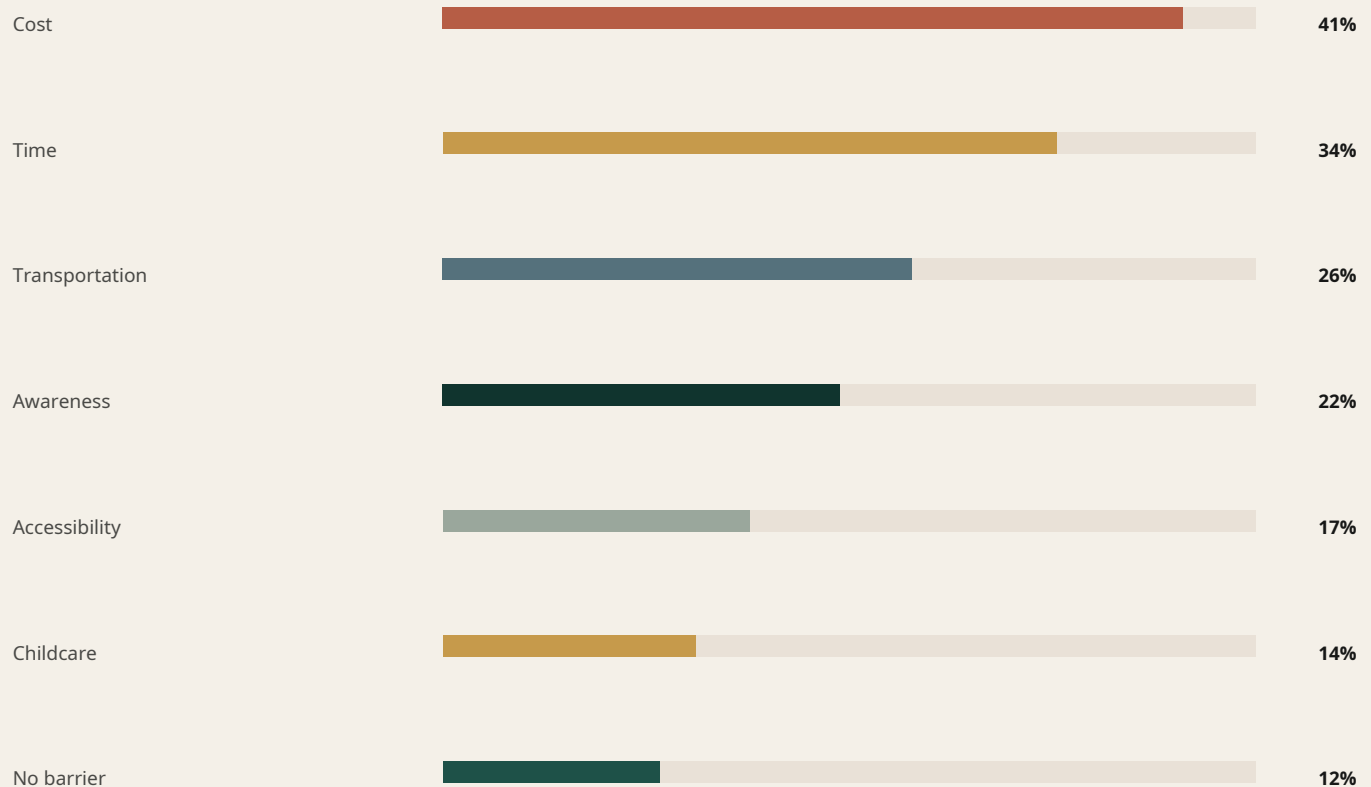


The chart is illustrative and demonstrates a vertical comparison system with direct labels rather than a separate legend.

BARRIERS

What keeps people away

Access is shaped by practical friction as much as by cultural interest.



Design cannot remove every barrier, but it can make cost, timing, transportation, accessibility, and expectations visible before a person commits.

02

Spaces shape access.

*The room communicates before the label does:
through entrances, sightlines, seating, light,
language, and the confidence to pause.*



ESSAY

The room before the program

The physical environment speaks before a program begins. A visible entrance communicates welcome. Seating communicates permission to pause. Clear signs reduce the fear of entering incorrectly. Staff presence, language access, lighting, and the scale of information all shape whether a cultural space feels legible.

Editorial and environmental design share the same responsibility: to order attention without flattening complexity. In a publication, hierarchy guides the reader through evidence and interpretation. In a space, hierarchy guides the visitor through arrival, orientation, participation, and return.

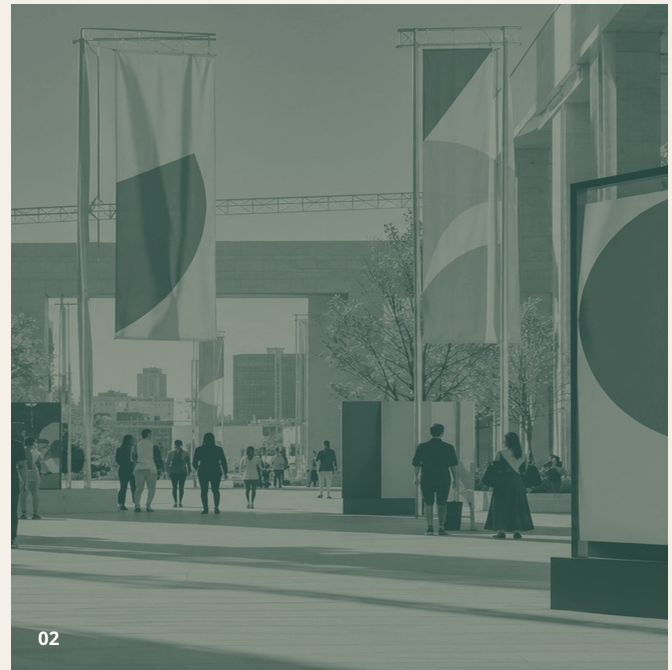


A layered interior can create intimacy and orientation when contrast and sightlines remain legible.

PHOTO ESSAY

Everyday thresholds

Four views of arrival, orientation, pause, and movement.



1 Arrival through a visible public edge. 2 Light as orientation. 3 The pause before interpretation. 4 Repetition as a wayfinding cue.

MODELED VOICES

What belonging sounds like

“I came for the workshop. I returned because someone remembered my name.”



MARA / PILSEN

“I need the details before I leave home: cost, entrance, timing, and whether I can bring my daughter.”



LEENA / ROGERS PARK

“The best programs feel local even when the institution is large.”



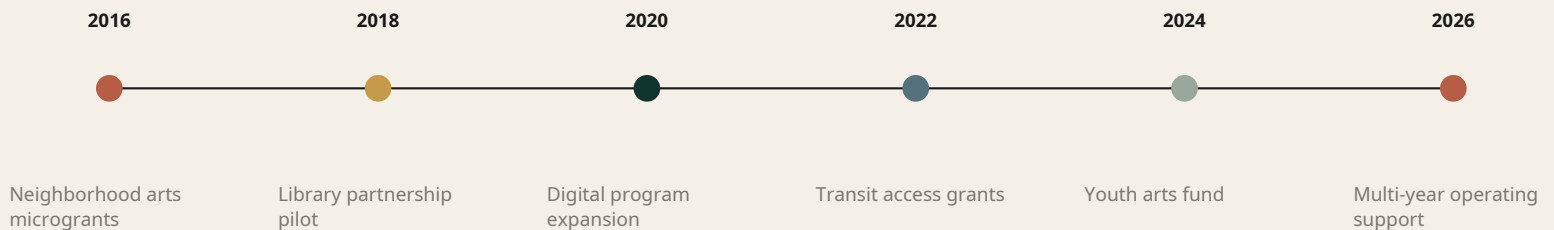
ANDRE / SOUTH SHORE

Participant quotations are fictional scenario content. They are included to demonstrate quote hierarchy, attribution, and the relationship between human testimony and analytical findings.

TIMELINE

A decade of cultural investment

Modeled milestones show how a timeline can hold policy, infrastructure, and programming in one reading sequence.



The timeline uses direct labels and a single horizontal reading path. It avoids a separate legend so every milestone remains attached to its year.

TABLE

Cultural facilities by district

A comparative table uses tabular figures, restrained rules, and alternating rows to support scanning.

District	Organizations	Programs	Annual attendance	Accessible entry
North	128	312	241,126	91%
West	96	218	173,402	82%
South	114	266	203,582	84%
Central	98	256	187,054	95%
Lakefront	80	214	139,723	89%
Total	516	1,266	944,887	88%

Values are modeled for this design project. Totals are internally consistent across the report.

COMMUNITY PATTERNS

Access is uneven, not random.

A dot field represents relative concentration of cultural facilities across modeled community areas.



PROFILES

Different places need different invitations

Harbor North

High awareness, crowded calendars

Opportunity: late hours and quick planning tools

West Junction

Strong community networks, lower institutional trust

Opportunity: partner-led programming

South Gardens

High creative participation, limited nearby venues

Opportunity: mobile and shared-space formats

03

Belonging is designed.

A return visit is built through small decisions: visible information, predictable care, and the confidence to participate without decoding the institution first.



ESSAY

Design for the return visit

Belonging is not an abstract brand value. It is the cumulative effect of small, repeatable decisions. Organizations build trust when schedules are predictable, information is plain, imagery reflects the surrounding community, and first-time visitors can understand what will happen before they arrive.

This is where graphic design moves beyond promotion. A campaign may create awareness, but a communication system creates continuity. The same tone, language, and hierarchy should carry from social post to registration page, from exterior sign to welcome desk, and from event reminder to follow-up invitation.

“Belonging grows when people do not have to prove that they understand the system before the system makes room for them.”

RECOMMENDATIONS

Make the invitation legible

OI

Publish the practical details

Cost, duration, entrance, accessibility, transportation, and expectations should appear before promotional language.

O2

Design for first-time visitors

Use plain language, visible staff roles, arrival photography, and confirmation messages that reduce uncertainty.

O3

Build with community partners

Let trusted local organizations shape distribution, timing, language, and the framing of participation.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Make return easier than arrival

04

Create a recognizable path

Repeat the same hierarchy across social, web, email, signage, and on-site information.

05

Invest in access infrastructure

Treat transportation, seating, language, digital accessibility, and childcare information as program design.

06

Measure confidence, not only attendance

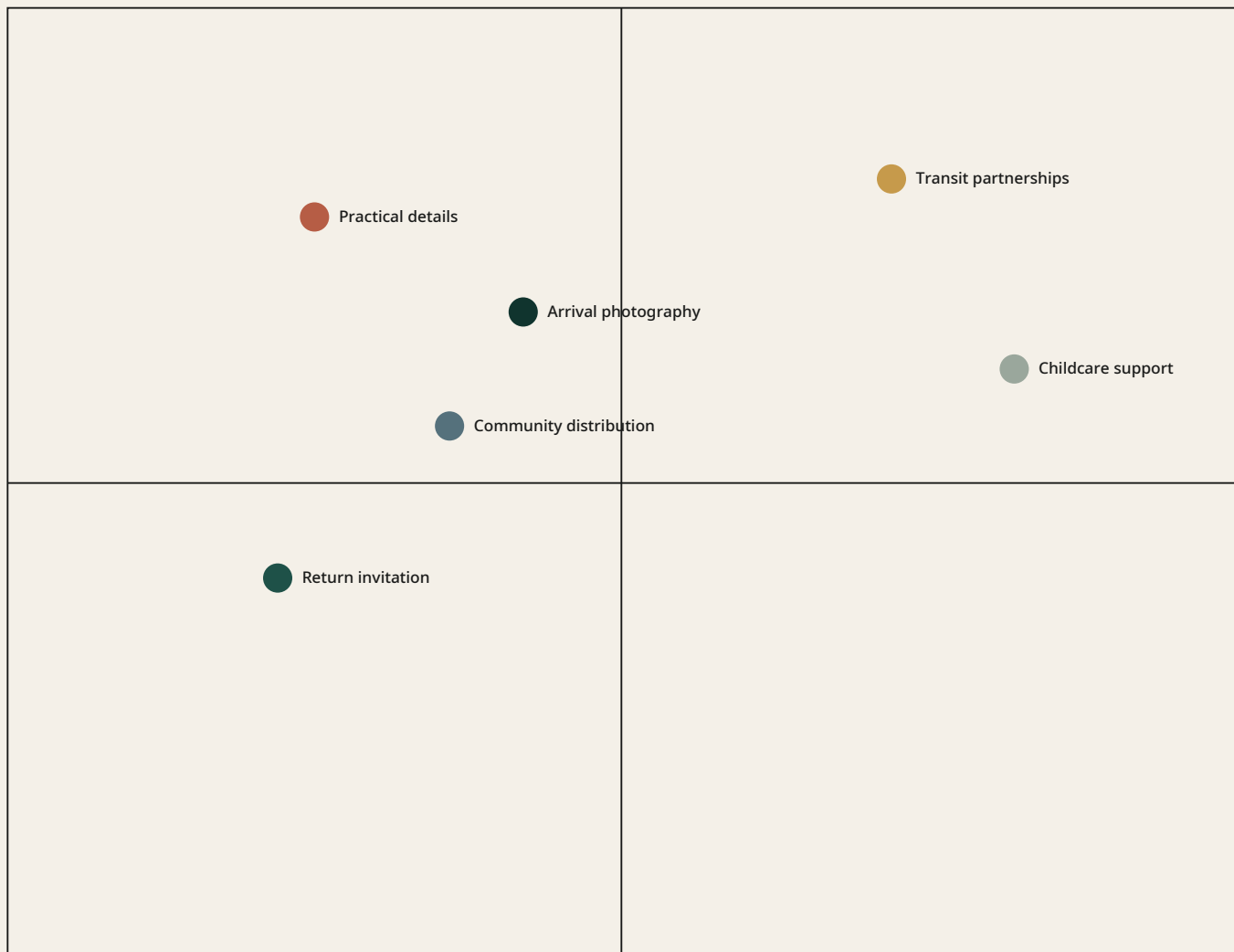
Track whether people understood the invitation, felt welcome, and could imagine returning.

IMPLEMENTATION

Start with high-confidence moments

The matrix prioritizes actions by expected access value and implementation effort.

HIGH ACCESS VALUE



HIGH EFFORT

METHODOLOGY

Methodology, sources, and limits

SCENARIO DATASET

A modeled survey of 1,204 respondents, constructed to demonstrate consistent charts, comparisons, and totals across the report.

MODELED INTERVIEWS

Three fictional participant voices used to demonstrate quotation hierarchy and attribution.

EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

Themes were organized around notice, understanding, effort, arrival, participation, and return.

LIMITATIONS

No finding in this publication should be treated as real evidence about Chicago residents or cultural organizations.

ACCESSIBILITY REVIEW

The publication uses direct labels, high-contrast text, consistent page furniture, and color-independent chart values.

PRODUCTION STATUS

This PDF is a portfolio prototype. A production edition would be rebuilt and preflighted in InDesign before print.

Source note: every statistic, quotation, district name, organization count, and financial value is illustrative scenario content. The project evaluates editorial design—not cultural policy.

COLOPHON

Built as a repeatable editorial system

TRIM

8.5 × 11 in

BLEED

0.125 in

GRID

6 columns / page

BASELINE

14 pt

BODY

10.2 / 14 pt

BINDING

Perfect bound

COLOR

CMYK target

EXPORT

PDF/X-4 target

PARAGRAPH STYLES

Display / Section title / Lead / Body / Body small / Pull quote /
Caption / Footnote / Running head / Folio

CHARACTER STYLES

Small caps / Italic / Bold / Tabular figures / Source note / Accent
color

Type: EB Garamond and Noto Sans. Images are concept assets. Final production would require linked high-resolution originals, packaged fonts and licenses, preflight, color proofing, and a physical dummy.



A city becomes more legible
when more people can imagine
themselves inside its stories.

Common Ground / 2026